

Looking beyond profits

Dani reiterated that when the league was created, the motive was never to make money but to give back to the game. While the idea is noble, finances need to be in the green for the franchises involved to stay afloat.

This year, Dabang Delhi became the second franchise in UTT history to break even. Its CEO Prashant Ramesh Mishra said, "At present, franchise revenues are driven primarily through sponsorships, central commercial revenues shared by the league and prudent financial management rather than broadcast

Signs of promise: Like previous editions, this edition too saw young Indian paddlers making their mark, such as Syndrela Das and Abhinandh P. B., both of whom represented the Challengers. UTT

distributions alone. Also, UTT has been giving better central pool returns year-on-year, showcasing a strong upward trend."

"As UTT continues to expand its audience and commercial footprint, we believe media rights and broadcast revenues will naturally become a more significant component of franchise economics, much like what we've seen in other mature sports leagues," he added.

U Mumba is also said to be quite close to breaking even. In 2024, the Goa Challengers had become the first team to do so.

"Some of them will make money also," Dani chimed in proudly.

"Each franchise has to put in some effort to generate revenue, and we are also doing things centrally so that we can get that load off them. We are one of the most economically well-run leagues, and our model is

truly frugal in terms of spending. Even after that, when young players are prospering and proving themselves, it's heartening for me. That's my ROI (Return on Investment)," she added.

Future stars shine

Over the last couple of years, many young Indian paddlers have taken the UTT stage by storm and announced themselves with wins against higher-ranked players. This edition saw some more names added to that list, especially Syndrela Das and Abhinandh P. B., both of whom represented the Challengers.

The spotlight was well and truly on Syndrela after she blanked one of her childhood idols, Manika Batra, in her second match of the season. The 16-year-old, who's part of India's Asian Games squad, also impressed at the recently concluded

